Broadcastwell Research

Head to Head: who the engines pick when a buyer asks A or B. October 2026.

Data: the September 2026 Absence Index deposit, DOI 10.5281/zenodo.22907695. The answers read here were captured on 22 September 2026. This study: DOI assigned at release. License CC BY 4.0.

From the September 2026 Absence Index deposit (DOI 10.5281/zenodo.22907695; verbatim answers from ChatGPT, Claude, Perplexity, Google AI Overviews and Google AI Mode, three repeats per question), we read every answer to a head to head question ("A vs B") and every answer to an alternatives question ("alternatives to X") across 14 categories. We report how often an answer declares a single winner, who wins, whether the five engines agree, whether the winner is the more-named vendor in the Index, and what the winning answers cite.

75 of 359
head to head answers declared a single winner (20.9 percent).

271 of 359
gave each vendor to a different kind of buyer instead (75.5 percent).

1 of 24
head to head questions had all five engines pick the same winner.

524 of 540
alternatives answers named the incumbent beyond restating the question.

Data and question set

The question rule: from the deposit's release record, every target question whose text is an "A vs B" comparison (it contains " vs " or " versus ") and every target question that asks for alternatives to a named vendor ("alternatives to X"). That gives 24 head to head questions and 36 alternatives questions in 12 of the deposit's 14 categories; the two remaining categories (CRM and project management) have no question of either kind. Each question was asked of five engines three times, so 360 head to head answers and 540 alternatives answers. The deposit's exclusion records leave 359 and 540 scored answers; every count below is on scored answers only. The one excluded answer is a Google AI Overviews repeat where no overview was returned.

Category	Head to head questions	Alternatives questions	Answers	Scored
Construction project management	2	3	75	75
Dealership management systems	2	3	75	75
Dental practice management	2	3	75	75
Field service management	2	3	75	75
Hotel property management	2	3	75	75
Insurance agency management	2	3	75	75

Category	Head to head questions	Alternatives questions	Answers	Scored
Legal practice management	2	3	75	75
Loan origination software	2	3	75	75
Radiology and medical imaging	2	3	75	75
Residential property management	2	3	75	74
Transportation management systems	2	3	75	75
Veterinary practice management	2	3	75	75

How the answers were read

The coding rule: An answer declares a winner when its own recommendation sentence names one of the two vendors as the better choice for the question as asked. "Depends" with no pick is coded depends; a pick for each of two buyer types is coded both; a refusal or an answer naming neither is coded neither. The first-named vendor is the first of the two to appear in the text. Cited domains are classed as A's own site, B's own site, a third-party page, or none. Every answer was read twice; disagreements between the two reads were resolved by a third read and logged.

Two passes read every answer in full, each blind to the other. Both passes, the third reads and a consistency read were made by instances of the same AI model (Claude) working from one written rule and a precedent list, not by human coders, so agreement between the passes is not evidence that people would code the same way. The two head to head passes disagreed on 11 of 360 answers; each was settled by a third read. One precedent was fixed at that read: a pick tied to a condition the question does not state ("A is usually better if your priority is X") is a split, coded both. Because the passes had read that wording both ways, every agreed A or B code whose deciding sentence carried a condition was read a third time under it, and 22 codes changed to both. The alternatives passes named the same set of vendors in most answers once spellings were folded together; 23 alternatives entries went to a third read. The first-named vendor and the cited domain classes are computed by script; vendor names follow the Index record and its published aliases. The full rule, the precedents, both passes and the third-read log are in the data files.

The winner rate per engine and overall

Overall, 75 of 359 (20.9 percent; 95 percent interval 17.0 to 25.4) scored head to head answers named one vendor as the better choice for the buyer as asked. The most common verdict was both: 271 of 359 answers gave each vendor to a different buyer or situation. Depends: 12. Neither: 1 (a request-limit message returned as the answer).

Engine	Declared a single winner	A or B	Both	Depends	Neither
ChatGPT	23 of 72 (31.9 percent; 95 percent interval 22.3 to 43.4)	23	49	0	0
Claude	15 of 72 (20.8 percent; 95 percent interval 13.1 to 31.6)	15	52	5	0
Perplexity	21 of 72 (29.2 percent; 95 percent interval 19.9 to 40.5)	21	51	0	0
Google AI Overviews	11 of 71 (15.5 percent; 95 percent interval 8.9 to 25.7)	11	54	6	0
Google AI Mode	5 of 72 (6.9 percent; 95 percent interval 3.0 to 15.2)	5	65	1	1

Base per engine: 72 scored answers (71 for Google AI Overviews). Repeats of one question are correlated, so true uncertainty is wider than the interval shown.

The winner table by category

Counts per question, out of its scored answers. Leader: the vendor named the winner more often (tie or no winner declared otherwise). Index named count: how many of the category's Index answers named each vendor in the September release (A / B, of the base shown).

Category	Question	A wins	B wins	Both	Depends	Neither	Base	Leader	Index named count
Construction project management	Procore vs Buildertrend	0	11	3	0	1	15	Buildertrend	109 / 83 of 150
Construction project management	Kahua vs e-Builder	0	0	15	0	0	15	no winner declared	not both measured
Dealership management systems	Tekion vs CDK	0	0	14	1	0	15	no winner declared	76 / 90 of 150
Dealership management systems	DealerCenter vs Frazer	3	3	9	0	0	15	tie	79 / 59 of 150
Dental practice management	Open Dental vs Dentrix	1	0	13	1	0	15	Open Dental	118 / 120 of 149
Dental practice management	Dentrix vs Eaglesoft	0	0	15	0	0	15	no winner declared	120 / 69 of 149
Field service management	Jobber vs Housecall Pro	1	1	12	1	0	15	tie	50 / 108 of 150
Field service management	FieldEdge vs ServiceTitan	0	0	15	0	0	15	no winner declared	44 / 102 of 150
Hotel property management	Mews vs Cloudbeds	0	0	15	0	0	15	no winner declared	48 / 115 of 149
Hotel property management	Maestro PMS vs RoomKeyPMS	0	4	11	0	0	15	RoomKeyPMS	43 / 15 of 149
Insurance agency management	HawkSoft vs EZLynx	1	0	14	0	0	15	HawkSoft	97 / 127 of 150
Insurance agency management	Applied Epic vs EZLynx	0	2	13	0	0	15	EZLynx	127 / 127 of 150
Legal practice management	Clio vs MyCase	2	3	10	0	0	15	MyCase	126 / 96 of 150
Legal practice management	CosmoLex vs Rocket Matter	0	0	9	6	0	15	no winner declared	77 / 26 of 150
Loan origination software	MeridianLink vs nCino	0	0	15	0	0	15	no winner declared	81 / 92 of 150
Loan origination software	Encompass vs Blend	2	0	13	0	0	15	Encompass	62 / 22 of 150

Category	Question	A wins	B wins	Both	Depends	Neither	Base	Leader	Index named count
Radiology and medical imaging	Sectra vs Visage Imaging	6	0	7	2	0	15	Sectra	87 / 65 of 150
Radiology and medical imaging	Visage vs Intelerad	0	6	9	0	0	15	Intelerad	65 / 80 of 150
Residential property management	Buildium vs AppFolio	0	0	14	0	0	14	no winner declared	119 / 95 of 148
Residential property management	Yardi Breeze vs Buildium	0	7	8	0	0	15	Buildium	71 / 119 of 148
Transportation management systems	AscendTMS vs Alvys	6	0	9	0	0	15	AscendTMS	64 / 58 of 150
Transportation management systems	Truckbase vs Alvys	3	0	12	0	0	15	Truckbase	not both measured
Veterinary practice management	ezyVet vs Cornerstone	13	0	2	0	0	15	ezyVet	115 / 90 of 149
Veterinary practice management	Shepherd vs Digitail	0	0	14	1	0	15	no winner declared	56 / 67 of 149

Agreement

Across repeats: on 89 of 119 (74.8 percent; 95 percent interval 66.3 to 81.7) question and engine pairs, all three repeats gave the same verdict; on 13 of 119 pairs, all three named the same single winner (base: pairs with three scored repeats).

Across engines: taking each engine's majority verdict over its three repeats, all five engines picked the same winner on 1 of 24 head to head questions, and gave the same verdict of any kind on 12 of 24. At least one engine's majority named a single winner on 11 of 24 questions, and on 1 of 24 questions one engine's majority named A while another's named B.

Winner against the Index named count

Where an answer declared a winner and both vendors carry an Index record with different named counts, the winner was the vendor the Index found named more often in 46 of 70 (65.7 percent; 95 percent interval 54.0 to 75.8) answers. 3 winning answers are left out because one vendor is outside the Index's checked set for that category (it was not measured), and 2 because the two counts are equal.

First-named vendor: the answer named the question's first vendor (A) before B in 256 of 359 (71.3 percent; 95 percent interval 66.4 to 75.7) scored answers. Among answers with a winner, the winner was the first-named vendor in 69 of 75, and the winner was A in 38 of 75.

What winning answers cite

Among the 75 answers that declared a winner: 45 of 75 cited the winner's own site, 31 of 75 cited the rival's own site, 63 of 75 cited at least one third-party page, and 0 of 75 cited nothing. By citation: 68 links to the winner's site, 51 to the rival's, 624 to third-party pages (743 in all). Own site means the vendor's canonical domain in the Index record or a subdomain of it.

Engine	Winning answers	Cite winner's site	Cite rival's site	Cite a third party	Cite nothing
ChatGPT	23	17 of 23	21 of 23	11 of 23	0 of 23
Claude	15	5 of 15	1 of 15	15 of 15	0 of 15
Perplexity	21	12 of 21	4 of 21	21 of 21	0 of 21
Google AI Overviews	11	8 of 11	3 of 11	11 of 11	0 of 11
Google AI Mode	5	3 of 5	2 of 5	5 of 5	0 of 5

The ten most-cited third-party domains in winning answers

Domain	Winning answers citing it
ustechautomations.com	26 of 75
capterra.com	21 of 75
reddit.com	16 of 75
softwareadvice.com	13 of 75
g2.com	11 of 75
projul.com	10 of 75
puppilot.co	10 of 75
selecthub.com	10 of 75
engage.klasresearch.com	9 of 75
getapp.com	7 of 75

Alternatives: first-named alternatives and incumbents

For each "alternatives to X" question: the alternative named first most often, the runner-up, how many different vendors were named first, the vendor offered most often anywhere in the list, and how often X itself was named beyond a restatement of the question. Overall, the most common first alternative of its question accounted for 384 of 540 scored answers; on 9 of 36 questions every answer led with the same alternative.

Category	X	Named first most often	Runner-up	Different firsts	Offered most often	X named
Construction project management	Procore	Autodesk Construction Cloud (15 of 15)		1	Autodesk Construction Cloud (15 of 15)	15 of 15

Category	X	Named first most often	Runner-up	Different firsts	Offered most often	X named
Construction project management	Buildertrend	JobTread (11 of 15)	Procore (2)	4	Contractor Foreman (15 of 15)	15 of 15
Construction project management	Autodesk Construction Cloud	Procore (15 of 15)		1	Procore (15 of 15)	15 of 15
Dealership management systems	CDK Global	Tekion (9 of 15)	DealerCenter (4)	3	DealerCenter (15 of 15)	15 of 15
Dealership management systems	Reynolds and Reynolds	Tekion (8 of 15)	CDK Global (7)	2	CDK Global (15 of 15)	15 of 15
Dealership management systems	Dealertrack DMS	CDK Global (9 of 15)	Tekion (6)	2	CDK Global (15 of 15)	15 of 15
Dental practice management	Dentrix	Open Dental (13 of 15)	Curve Dental (2)	2	CareStack (15 of 15)	15 of 15
Dental practice management	Eaglesoft	Curve Dental (9 of 15)	Open Dental (6)	2	Curve Dental (15 of 15)	15 of 15
Dental practice management	Open Dental	Curve Dental (11 of 15)	Dentrix (3)	3	Curve Dental (15 of 15)	15 of 15
Field service management	ServiceTitan	Jobber (10 of 15)	Housecall Pro (5)	2	Housecall Pro (15 of 15)	14 of 15
Field service management	Housecall Pro	Jobber (15 of 15)		1	Jobber (15 of 15)	15 of 15
Field service management	Jobber	Housecall Pro (15 of 15)		1	Housecall Pro (15 of 15)	15 of 15
Hotel property management	Opera PMS	Cloudbeds (10 of 15)	Mews (5)	2	Cloudbeds (15 of 15)	15 of 15
Hotel property management	Cloudbeds	Little Hotelier (9 of 15)	Mews (6)	2	Little Hotelier (15 of 15)	15 of 15
Hotel property management	Maestro PMS	Cloudbeds (9 of 15)	Agilysys (3)	4	Cloudbeds (15 of 15)	15 of 15
Insurance agency management	EZLynx	Applied Epic (11 of 15)	HawkSoft (4)	2	AMS360 (15 of 15)	15 of 15
Insurance agency management	Applied Epic	AMS360 (14 of 15)	QQCatalyst (1)	2	AMS360 (15 of 15)	15 of 15
Insurance agency management	AgencyZoom	InsuredMine (6 of 15)	EZLynx (3)	5	AgencyBloc (12 of 15)	15 of 15
Legal practice management	Clio	MyCase (15 of 15)		1	CosmoLex (15 of 15)	15 of 15

Category	X	Named first most often	Runner-up	Different firsts	Offered most often	X named
Legal practice management	PracticePanther	Clio (15 of 15)		1	Clio (15 of 15)	15 of 15
Legal practice management	Smokeball	Clio (15 of 15)		1	Clio (15 of 15)	15 of 15
Loan origination software	Encompass	LendingPad (6 of 15)	ARIVE (3)	5	LendingPad (12 of 15)	15 of 15
Loan origination software	MeridianLink	nCino (4 of 15)	Encompass (3)	7	nCino (15 of 15)	15 of 15
Loan origination software	nCino	Abrigo (12 of 15)	Encompass (2)	3	Abrigo (15 of 15)	15 of 15
Radiology and medical imaging	Sectra PACS	Visage Imaging (8 of 15)	Agfa HealthCare Enterprise Imaging (4)	3	Fujifilm Synapse (15 of 15)	15 of 15
Radiology and medical imaging	Intelerad	Sectra (7 of 15)	RamSoft (4)	4	Sectra (14 of 15)	15 of 15
Radiology and medical imaging	Philips IntelliSpace PACS	Sectra (15 of 15)		1	Fujifilm Synapse (15 of 15)	15 of 15
Residential property management	AppFolio	Buildium (14 of 15)	Rent Manager (1)	2	Buildium (15 of 15)	15 of 15
Residential property management	Buildium	DoorLoop (12 of 15)	AppFolio (3)	2	AppFolio (15 of 15)	13 of 15
Residential property management	Azibo	Baselane (11 of 15)	TurboTenant (4)	2	Stessa (15 of 15)	15 of 15
Transportation management systems	MercuryGate	Oracle Transportation Management (9 of 15)	Descartes (3)	3	Oracle Transportation Management (15 of 15)	13 of 15
Transportation management systems	AscendTMS	Tailwind TMS (5 of 15)	Freightview (4)	5	McLeod Software (12 of 15)	10 of 15
Transportation management systems	McLeod	Tai TMS (11 of 15)	Descartes (2)	4	Tai TMS (15 of 15)	13 of 15
Veterinary practice management	IDEXX Cornerstone	ezyVet (15 of 15)		1	ezyVet (15 of 15)	15 of 15
Veterinary practice management	ezyVet	Covetrus Pulse (6 of 15)	Shepherd (5)	4	Shepherd (15 of 15)	15 of 15
Veterinary practice management	Covetrus Pulse	ezyVet (5 of 15)	IDEXX Cornerstone (4)	4	ezyVet (15 of 15)	11 of 15

Engine	Alternatives answers naming X beyond the question
ChatGPT	107 of 108 (99.1 percent; 95 percent interval 94.9 to 99.8)
Claude	108 of 108 (100.0 percent; 95 percent interval 96.6 to 100.0)
Perplexity	104 of 108 (96.3 percent; 95 percent interval 90.9 to 98.6)
Google AI Overviews	100 of 108 (92.6 percent; 95 percent interval 86.1 to 96.2)
Google AI Mode	105 of 108 (97.2 percent; 95 percent interval 92.1 to 99.1)

What the study does not prove

The deposit records answers observed on 22 and 23 September 2026 under method v1.1. A verdict is the answer's wording on that date, not a judgment of product quality. Repeats of one question are correlated, so true uncertainty is wider than the interval shown. A vendor absent from a question's checked set was not measured.

The reads were made by AI model instances under a written rule, not by human coders; the rule, every code and every third read are published so anyone can re-read an answer and disagree. The questions are the Index's own wording, one or two per category, so they stand for those questions only, not for every way a buyer might ask.

Dispute route

The Index's own policy applies: any named vendor may ask for one same-configuration re-run per release at no charge, and both results are published. Write to index@broadcastwell.com.

Files and DOI

HEAD_TO_HEAD_QUESTIONS.csv (the question set), HEAD_TO_HEAD_DATA.csv (one row per answer: category, question, type, engine, repeat, scored or excluded, verdict or first alternative, first-named vendor, named list in order, X named, cited domain classes, cited domains and addresses, capture date, both passes), HEAD_TO_HEAD_CODING_RULE.md, the reader brief, both passes and the third-read log, under CC BY 4.0. Repository release DOI: assigned at release. Source deposit: DOI 10.5281/zenodo.22907695.

Broadcastwell LLC, 517 E Kirkwood Ave, Bloomington, IN 47408. hello@broadcastwell.com. Cite as: Broadcastwell (2026). Head to Head: who the engines pick when a buyer asks A or B. October 2026.